

FEATURE

THE STORY OF ABERI
BALYA: AFRICA'S FIRST
BAREFOOT BISHOP

BY JOSEPH BATTE

When Ugandans list the great pillars of the Anglican Church, names like Archbishop Janan Luwum, that fearless martyr and Bishop James Hannington, the sainted missionary, they cannot skip The Right Reverend Bishop Aberi Kakyomya Balya, Order of the British Empire (OBE).

He lived simply, walked humbly, and feared no man. Not even kings! Once, during a visit to Omukama Sir George Rukidi of Tooro at his palace in Kabarole, Balya found the royal in the most unholy condition. He was drunk beyond dignity. Most men would have pretended not to notice; not Bishop Balya.

Come Sunday morning, in front of the entire congregation, courtiers, nobles and the same king seated in front, Bishop Balya thundered from the pulpit: "You fool!" The church fell silent. Gasps filled the air. The king blinked, probably wondering whether heaven had just issued him a personal memo.

It was a moment that defined Balya's ministry: Fearless truth-telling wrapped in divine authority. For Bishop Balya, righteousness did not bend before a throne.

BAREFOOT BEFORE
GOD AND MAN

In 1948, when Sir Edward Mutesa, the Kabaka of Buganda, married Lady Damalie Kisosonkole at St Paul's Cathedral, Namirembe, Balya stood beside Bishop Stuart to assist in the grand ceremony. History remembers the glittering procession, the royal vows and the pageantry, but Balya? He remained barefoot!

Even when Queen Elizabeth's government honoured him with the Order of the British Empire in 1952, Bishop Balya accepted it with grace and bare feet firmly on the

ground. It was his quiet rebellion against vanity and his testament to the God who "lifts the humble and casts down the proud."

THE STREET, THE
STATUE, AND THE LEGACY

Today, in Fort Portal, his legacy still breathes. The town's Main Street bears his name, a daily reminder that greatness can walk softly.

Right in the middle of a traffic island stands his statue: Dignified, and yes, barefoot. The concrete figure watches over honking taxis and pedestrians, as if blessing every journey that passes. To the people of Tooro, he is not just a bishop of the past.

He is a living spirit in stone. Those who pause to gaze at his likeness often whisper a prayer, or at least a smile. "See him," they say. "The bishop who walked with God, without shoes."

THE ROOTS OF
A HOLY JOURNEY

Bishop Balya was born around 1877 in Rwahunga village, in Mpara sub-county, Tooro. His father, Kebisingo Rwingonyangabu, came from the Muliisa clan and his mother, Korwizi Kaisirwa, from the Muhinda clan of Kaaro Karungi.

The family migrated from Ankole to Tooro, bringing along their herds of cattle and a heart full of hope. Their ancestors, Bukuuju and his children Kataizi, Kinyonyi and Iremera, once lived in Kyabukuju, Mpororo, Ntungamo, before moving to Buhweju (also called Buzimba-Ibanda). The old stories say they followed an eagle, a divine guide that led them across hills and valleys, until they found their home.

From these mystical beginnings, Balya inherited both strength and a deep sense of destiny. His family tree was vast, stretching from Tooro to Ankole, linking him to people of stature, like Kisuuga, father of

A BISHOP
OF BISHOPS

In a letter from the Archbishop of Canterbury himself, Bishop Balya was given an extraordinary task: to conduct the enthronement ceremony of Archbishop Brown at Namirembe Cathedral.

It was a scene rich in symbolism: the African bishop, once deemed "too old and too simple," now stood at the heart of East African Christendom, representing not just Uganda but the Archbishops of Kenya and Sudan as well.

There, surrounded by bishops, kings, and foreign dignitaries, Bishop Aberi Balya performed one of his final public acts of service, installing his successor with the grace, dignity, and barefoot humility that had defined his ministry for decades.

Lazaro Saabu, and Murangira, father of Rudiya Kakurora, grandmother to King Olimi Kaboyo. The Balya lineage reads like a tapestry of Uganda's royal and spiritual heritage.

FROM WAR TO WISDOM

In the early 1890s, young Balya's life took a dramatic turn when he joined his father, Kebisingo, in a military campaign during the fierce wars between Kabalega of Bunyoro-Kitara and the invading British forces.

The war was a furnace. Kabalega's resistance burned bright, but ended in defeat, exile and ruin. The land was scarred, homes

destroyed, lives lost. Yet through the smoke and chaos, young Balya and his father survived.

They fled through Buruli, crossed Lake Kyoga and even endured a terrifying boat accident that nearly ended their journey. They wandered into Lango, weary, but alive, before finally finding their way back home to Tooro.

Those harrowing days hardened the boy into a man of remarkable resolve. Every escape, every loss, every tear was a seed of faith taking root.

THE HAND OF PROVIDENCE

Tragedy, however, was not done with him. The deaths of both parents left Balya adrift, moving from place to place under the care of his brother Bisanga Engumi, and sister Katetegerwe. Calamities seemed to chase him; droughts, diseases and the loss of cattle, until at last, grace found him.

He heard tales of a new ruler in Tooro, King Daudi Kasagama, a Christian monarch known for his kindness and faith. Hope stirred in Balya's heart. He set off to join the king's service.

His cousins Saabu and Murangira were already there.

THE MAKING OF THE
BAREFOOT SAINT

Every great journey of faith begins with a whisper. A small "yes" that changes everything.

For Balya, that whisper became a lifelong echo when he stepped into the waters of baptism on April 7, 1901.

By November 30, 1902, he was confirmed. Body, mind and soul

now pledged to Christ.

Missionaries Miss Pike and the Rev. Johnson of the Church Missionary Society (CMS) spotted his brilliance early and took him under their wing. With their support, Balya began teaching at Kabarole Mixed School.

"HERE I AM, LORD. SEND
ME."

In 1903, while serving as a curate at Kabarole, Balya experienced what prophets might call a "holy calling." Like Isaiah hearing God's voice thunder, "Whom shall I send?" (Isaiah 6:8), Balya felt a divine pull that set his heart ablaze. From that moment, his destiny was sealed. He would be a messenger of the Gospel.

Two years later, in 1905, he was sent to Ankole. There, the barefoot preacher moved from village to village. He preached, he taught, he baptised and in a feat that still stirs awe, even the king of Ankole embraced the faith.

LOVE, MARRIAGE
AND MISSION

On February 25, 1907, Balya entered a new chapter of life — he married Ketura, a teacher who had once served the Queen Mother. She was educated, faithful and as committed to service as her husband. The two were soon posted to Mboga, deep in the Congo, where they began their joint mission.

The following year, 1908, found them back in Uganda, in Kitagwenda (Kamwenge district).



Across Uganda, the name Bishop Aberi Kakyomya Balya continues to echo not only in church hymns, but also on school walls, college gates and city streets

HOMES & C
PLASCON BUDGET EM

BY UMAR NSUBUGA

When it comes to painting, most people focus on the final colour, the sheen, the transformation — the beauty that meets the eye. The reality is that perfection begins beneath the surface. The real secret to a flawless, long-lasting finish lies in proper surface preparation which includes high quality Undercoat. Beneath every vibrant wall is a hero that ensures smoothness, adhesion and durability. Kansai Plascon Uganda has mastered this science with its Plascon Budget Emulsion Undercoat, a trusted product transforming both home and commercial projects across Uganda, South Sudan, DRC, Burundi and Rwanda.

According to Daniel Kayongo, the head of marketing at Kansai Plascon Uganda, the beauty and durability of any paint job depend on its foundation. "A perfect finish starts with a perfect base. The

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